

Gospel, Lord, Savior: Caesar's Words in Christian Mouths

The vocabulary of Christian confession was in public circulation before the church ever used it, and the man it pointed to lived in Rome.

THE CLAIM

The Words Were Already Taken

Gospel. Lord. Savior. We hear these as church words, soft with familiarity, the vocabulary of stained glass and Sunday morning. The first readers of the New Testament heard something else. These words were already in public use before a single Christian spoke them, and they belonged to the empire.

By the time Mark opened his book with 'the beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ,' the Greek word euangelion had a long public career. It announced imperial good news. A victory in battle. The birth of an heir. The accession of a new emperor. The first Christians did not invent their vocabulary in a prayer meeting. They picked it up off the street, where it was already attached to a throne.

This does not make the New Testament a political pamphlet. It makes it a book written by people who knew exactly how their words sounded in public. We read them quietly, devotionally, with the volume turned down. The first hearers had no such option.

THE EVIDENCE

A Birthday in Priene

Around 9 BC, the cities of the Roman province of Asia reorganized their calendar so that the new year began on the birthday of Caesar Augustus. An inscription recording the decision was found at Priene, on the western coast of modern Turkey. It praises Augustus as a savior sent by providence, a benefactor whose coming ended war and set the world in order. Then comes the famous line. The birthday of the god, it says, was for the world the beginning of good tidings that came because of him. The word is a form of euangelion. Gospel.

This is not an obscure scrap. Copies of the decree stood in multiple cities. The language was standard

imperial praise, the kind of speech ordinary people heard at festivals and read on public stones.

So when Mark calls his account the beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, Son of God, he is using a sentence shape his world already knew. Whether he intended a direct challenge or simply spoke the available language is debated. What is not debated is this. The word was not blank when the church received it.

THE TITLES

Lord and Savior Were Job Titles

Kyrios, the Greek word for lord, was an everyday term. A slave used it for a master. A tenant used it for a landlord. But it also climbed. Papyri from Egypt speak of Nero as the lord. Inscriptions across the eastern Mediterranean honor emperors as theos and soter, god and savior. Julius Caesar was hailed in Ephesus as a god made manifest and a common savior of human life. Decades later, the historian Suetonius reports that Domitian welcomed the address dominus et deus, lord and god.

Soter, savior, was the standard word for a benefactor who delivered a city from famine, war, or debt. It was civic language before it was religious language, though that distinction is ours, not theirs. In the first century, politics and worship shared one altar.

Into this world the church said two things at once. Jesus is Lord. Jesus is Savior. To us these are doctrine. To a first-century ear they were also a comparison, whether or not the speaker stressed it. There was already a lord of the world, and his face was on the coins.

THE COST

What the Confession Cost

In Thessalonica, the charge against the first missionaries was civic, not merely religious. These men are acting against the decrees of Caesar, the crowd said, claiming there is another king, Jesus. That is Acts 17, and it shows how the message could be heard even when Paul was preaching Israel's Messiah from Israel's Scriptures.

The cost became literal. Around AD 112, the Roman governor Pliny wrote to the emperor Trajan describing his test for accused Christians. They were ordered to invoke the gods, offer wine and incense to the image of the emperor, and curse Christ. Real Christians, he had learned, could not be forced to do these things. A generation later, the aged bishop Polycarp was asked what harm there could be in saying Caesar is lord and offering a pinch of incense. He refused and was burned.

The confession that Jesus is Lord was free to make and costly to keep. We say it now with no risk at all. That should not make us read it as if it never carried any.

SOBER READING

How Hard to Press This

Some scholars, N. T. Wright among them, hear a deliberate counter-imperial note running through Paul. If Jesus is Lord, then Caesar is not, and Paul knew it. Others urge caution. John Barclay has argued that the Roman empire was, in a sense, insignificant to Paul. Not invisible. Insignificant. Paul rarely names Rome. His story runs from Adam through Abraham to the Messiah, and the powers he confronts are sin and death, which stand behind every empire and outlast them all. On this reading, Paul dethrones Caesar not by attacking him but by ignoring him, filing Rome under the present evil age without granting it a starring role.

The honest position holds both. The imperial resonance of gospel, lord, and savior is historically real. The degree of intended confrontation is genuinely contested. The New Testament's primary frame is Israel's story, not Rome's.

And here the point of context work surfaces. We do not learn this background to win arguments or to enlist Paul in our politics. I have been tempted to both. Context exists to put us under the text, not above it. The first Christians said Jesus is Lord in a world that had another candidate. So do we.

KEY TEXTS

Mark 1:1

Philippians 2:9-11

Acts 17:6-7

SOURCES

Backgrounds of Early Christianity — Everett Ferguson

Paul and the Faithfulness of God — N. T. Wright

Pauline Churches and Diaspora Jews — John M. G. Barclay

Honor, Patronage, Kinship and Purity — David A. deSilva